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Choppy Waters

The government did not rest on its oars after putting V.O. Chidambaram Pillai behind bars and teaching the people of Tirunelveli and Tuticorin a lesson. It now turned to strangling the Swadeshi Steam Navigation Company.

Writing days after the ‘riots’, in a demi-official letter, Wynch conceded that VOC had ‘undoubtedly acquired great influence’ which extended beyond Tuticorin. But he took comfort that his arrest had ‘practically [dealt] the death blow’ to the Swadeshi company.[1] In any case, the closing of the company was the main objective and not merely a desired by-product. Having dealt the blow, the government now set out to bury it and perform its last rites. All this was no secret. As *The Hindu* remarked, ‘It is significant that the authorities will not even decently hide their intention to “crush” the Swadeshi Steam Navigation Co.’[2]

The colonial state’s burning desire to see the company wiped out is abundantly clear from the extraordinarily rich documentation that I have unearthed. While the secret police went on overdrive, snooping on and shadowing the Swadeshi company and its various actors, submitting daily reports, Wynch and the officials in Madras City and in Ootacamund (the summer capital), not excluding Governor Lawley himself, frequently exchanged demi-official letters on how to deal with the company. If the *Madras Police Abstracts of Intelligence* is bursting with details about the everyday functioning of the company, a remarkable set of documents, buried away as ‘Secret Bundle no 43, “Sedition in Tinnevelly, 1908”’ in the confidential records section of the Tamilnadu Archives, shows how the highest officials of the land, unbridled by moral qualms or compunctions, schemed to crush the company and stamp out the anti-colonial movement in south India.